A · DE
POR · PARA
THE SMALL WORDS

which one goes where — and what it does to *el*

1. Spanish has exactly two contractions both need *el* — nothing else ever joins up

a + el → al
Voy **al** cine. · Llamo **al** médico. · Vamos **al** campo.

de + el → del
el coche **del** profesor · la parada **del** autobús · las flores **del** jardín

Everything else stays in two words. There is nothing to learn here — they simply don't merge:
Voy **a la** playa. · Voy **a los** Alpes. · la casa **de la** profesora. · el nombre **de las** calles.

So **del** and **de la** are not a choice you make. They are the same word *de*, standing in front of a masculine or a feminine noun. If the noun takes *la*, you write **de la**; the only reason **del** looks different is that *de el* may not be said out loud.
The one exception: **él** with an accent is the person *he*, and it never contracts — *se lo doy a él*, *el libro es de él*.

2. de — the all-purpose *of* six jobs, and English only uses *of* for two of them

whose it is	**el coche de Juan**	Juan's car · there is no apostrophe-s in Spanish, so it flips round
where it's from	**el queso es de España**	mi profesora es **de** Argentina · this is the *ser de* of origin
what it's made of	**una casa de madera**	a wooden house
how much of it	**un litro de leche**	una botella **de** agua · a quantity takes no article after *de*
what kind of thing	**clase de español**	zumo **de** naranja · billete **de** tren · fin **de** semana
what it's about	**un libro de historia**	a history book

And every word of place or time drags a **de** along behind it:
antes **de** · después **de** · cerca **de** · lejos **de** · dentro **de** · fuera **de** · delante **de** · detrás **de** · al lado **de**
Vivo cerca **del** centro. · Leo antes **de** dormir. · Trabajo fuera **de** Estocolmo.

3. a — movement, the clock, and people three unrelated jobs that happen to share one letter

towards somewhere	**Voy a Madrid.**	Llego **a** casa. · Salgo **a** la calle. · movement, not position
a time on the clock	**A las ocho.**	¿**A** qué hora empiezas? · always *a* once an hour is named
how often	**tres clases a la semana**	dos veces **al** día · English *a week* is Spanish *a la semana*
how it's done	**a pie**	**a** mano · **a la** derecha, **a la** izquierda
in front of a person	**Veo a mis amigos.**	the personal *a*: Llamo **a** mi madre · but *Veo la casa* — no person, no *a*

4. por vs para the one that takes longest — ask which way the sentence points

PARA → forwards, to the point of it

who it's for — Este regalo es **para** ti.
what for — Estudio **para** aprender. ¿**Para** qué?
by when — Lo necesito **para** el lunes.
where you're headed — Salgo **para** Madrid.
in someone's view — **Para** mí, es demasiado caro.

POR ← backwards, to the reason or the route

because of — Gracias **por** la ayuda. Lo hago **por** ti.
through, around — Paseo **por** el parque.
in exchange for — Lo compré **por** diez euros.
part of the day — **Por** la mañana. **Por** la noche.
by what means — **por** teléfono, **por** correo

para looks ahead at a goal; **por** looks back at a cause. *Un regalo **para** ti* = it's yours now. *Lo hago **por** ti* = I'm doing it because of you, for your sake.
Learn these whole — every one of them is **por**: por favor · por supuesto · por fin · por ejemplo · por eso · por qué.

5. Three near-misses one small word apart, and not the same sentence at all

¿Por qué? · Porque…
Two words **ask** why, one word **answers** because. And *¿para qué?* is a third question — **what for**, to what end.

por la mañana
No hour stated. Name one and it turns into *de*: **a las ocho de la mañana**. Never *por las ocho*.

pensar en · de
Pienso **en** ti — on my mind. ¿Qué piensas **de** esto? — your opinion. Pienso ir — I plan to, no preposition.

de and **a** are not translations of *of* and *to*. They are the words that certain other words demand, so learn them stuck to the word in front — *cerca de*, *antes de*, *a las ocho* — as single items.

ES · ESTÁ
HAY · QUE
WHAT MUST FOLLOW

the words that lock a preposition in place

6. es, está or hay what it is, where it is, or that it's there at all

es · son
What or who it is, and for good.
Es mi hermano. · **Es** profesor. · **Es** alto. · **Son** las tres. · **Son** 9,50 €.

está · están
Where it is, or how it is today.
Está en la cocina. · **Estoy** cansado. · La pantalla **está** rota.

hay
That it exists at all. One form for singular and plural — never *hayn*.
Hay un cajero. · **Hay** muchas personas.

hay introduces something new, so it goes with *un*, *dos*, *muchos* or nothing at all. **está** places something already named, so it goes with *el*, *la*, *mi*. First ***Hay*** *un cajero en la esquina* — there's a cash machine round here somewhere. Then *El cajero* ***está*** *en la esquina* — the one we mean is on the corner.

7. es de · es para · es por the verb is identical — the small word carries the whole meaning

Es de Juan.
It's Juan**'s**. The same *es de* also gives origin — *es de España* — and material — *es de madera*.

Es para Juan.
It's **for** Juan. He's the one who ends up with it.

Es por Juan.
It's **because of** Juan. He's the reason, not the recipient.

8. Verbs that lock on a or de before a second verb — leaving it out is the commonest slip

… A + infinitive

ir **a** — Voy **a** comer. the everyday future
empezar **a** — Empiezo **a** trabajar **a** las nueve.
aprender **a** — Aprendo **a** conducir.
volver **a** — Vuelvo **a** llamar. = to do it again
ayudar **a** · enseñar **a** · invitar **a**

… DE + infinitive

acabar **de** — Acabo **de** llegar. = I've just arrived
dejar **de** — Dejo **de** fumar. = to stop doing it
tener ganas **de** — Tengo ganas **de** viajar.
antes **de** / después **de** — Leo antes **de** dormir.
acordarse **de** · olvidarse **de** · depender **de**

9. que, en and con the other three that get locked to a word

tener **que** + verb — Tengo **que** estudiar. = I have to
hay **que** + verb — Hay **que** esperar. = one has to, nobody named
trabajar **en** — Trabajo **en** una oficina.
ir **en** — Voy **en** metro. but *a pie*, on foot

pensar **en** — Pienso **en** ti.
soñar **con** — Sueño **con** ir a España.
hablar **con** — Hablo **con** mi jefe.
estar de acuerdo **con** — Estoy de acuerdo **contigo.** con + ti = contigo

10. Where the two languages disagree half the mistakes live here — a preposition that is there in one and not the other

English has one, Spanish has none

buscar algo — to look *for* · Busco mis llaves.
escuchar música — to listen *to*
mirar la tele — to look *at*, to watch
esperar el autobús — to wait *for*
pedir un café · **pagar** la cuenta — to ask *for*, to pay *for*

Spanish demands one, English doesn't

jugar **a** — Juego **al** fútbol. I play football
entrar **en** — Entro **en** casa. I enter the house
subir **a** / bajar **de** — Bajo **del** tren.
casarse **con** — Se casa **con** Ana. she's marrying Ana

The one place the left column grows a preposition again: a **person** on the receiving end still takes the personal *a*. *Espero el autobús*, but *Espero* ***a*** *María*. *Miro la tele*, but *Miro* ***a*** *mi hermana*.

When a new verb turns up, write the preposition into the card with it — **acabar de**, not *acabar*. Nothing predicts which one a verb takes, and the two words learned together are one thing to remember instead of two.